

Views Culture

The Frame is Empty

How a surprisingly simple theft in 1911 turned a quiet Renaissance portrait into the most famous masterpiece in the world.

Book Details

Book: *The Thefts of the Mona Lisa: On Stealing the World's Most Famous Painting*

Author: Noah Charney

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BEFORE the morning of August 21, 1911, the *Mona Lisa* was not the undisputed global icon she is today. She sat quietly in Paris's Louvre Museum, admired by art critics but largely ignored by the general public, who preferred grand, dramatic historical paintings. All of that changed in a single, silent morning because of an unbelievably simple security flaw.

In his captivating book, *The Thefts of the Mona Lisa*, art historian Noah Charney guides readers through the stranger-than-fiction story of how a humble Italian handyman named Vincenzo Peruggia walked out of the world's largest museum with Leonardo da Vinci's masterpiece tucked under his arm.

Peruggia had been hired by the Louvre to build protective glass cases for some of its most valuable paintings. He knew the museum's habits, its lack of guards, and its weak security routines. On a Sunday night, he hid inside a storage closet. On Monday morning, while the museum was closed for maintenance, he simply walked out of the closet dressed in a white worker's smock, took the *Mona Lisa* off the wall, slipped it under his coat, and walked out into the Paris streets.

"Vincenzo Peruggia did not use high-tech tools or clever distractions; he relied entirely on the museum's relaxed attitude toward security."

The museum was so disorganized that it took a full 24 hours for anyone to even notice the painting was missing. When the public finally learned of the heist, a media storm erupted. Newspapers around the globe printed photos of the missing portrait, turning the *Mona Lisa* into an overnight sensation. People actually queued in massive lines just to stare at the empty space on the wall where the painting used to hang.

Raine—and in this case, Charney—illustrates how the crime actually created the legend. For over two years, the police were completely baffled. They even cross-examined famous figures like the painter Pablo Picasso, but they had no luck. Meanwhile, Peruggia kept the priceless painting hidden in the false bottom of a wooden trunk in his tiny, one-room apartment in Paris.

The mystery ended when Peruggia tried to sell the painting to an art dealer in Florence, Italy. He claimed he stole it out of patriotism, wanting to return the masterpiece to its native homeland. He was immediately arrested, and the *Mona Lisa* was returned to the Louvre under heavy guard.

Charney's book is more than just a fun true-crime story; it is an eye-opening look at how easily human systems can fail when we become too comfortable. It shows that sometimes, the most historic crimes do not require mastermind geniuses—just an empty hallway and an open door.

Reading Comprehension Questions

1. **According to the text, how did the general public view the *Mona Lisa* before the 1911 theft?**
2. Explain how Vincenzo Peruggia's job at the Louvre helped him execute the heist so easily.
3. **True or False:** The museum guards caught Peruggia as he was running out of the front doors with the painting.
4. What unexpected behavior did the public display at the museum while the painting was still missing?